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Head of Data Interoperability (Data Engineering)

Government Digital Service

Apply before 11:45 pm on Monday 2nd November 2026

Government Digital Service

Reference number

486563

Salary

£71,920 - £87,475

£76,975 - £87,475 (London) / £71,920 - £82,420 (National) Based on capability. The base salary of this grade is £76,475 for London and £71,420 for other locations. Offers made above this will be made up with a specialist pay allowance.

A Civil Service Pension with an employer contribution of 28.97%

Job grade

Grade 6

Contract type

Permanent

Business area

GDS - Data Group

Type of role

Digital

Working pattern

Flexible working, Full-time, Job share, Part-time, Compressed hours

Number of jobs available

1

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Location

Bristol, London, Manchester

About the job

Job summary

The Government Digital Service (GDS) is the digital centre of government. We are responsible for setting, leading and delivering the vision for a modern digital government.

Our priorities are to drive a modern digital government, by:

1. joining up public sector services
2. harnessing the power of AI for the public good
3. strengthening and extending our digital and data public infrastructure
4. elevating leadership and investing in talent
5. funding for outcomes and procuring for growth and innovation
6. committing to transparency and driving accountability

We are home to the Incubator for Artificial Intelligence (I.AI), the world-leading GOV.UK and at the forefront of coordinating the UK s geospatial strategy and activity. We lead the Government Digital and Data function and champion the work of digital teams across government.

We re part of the Department for Science, Innovation and Technology (DSIT) and employ more than 1,000 people all over the UK, with hubs in Manchester, London and Bristol.

The Government Digital Service is where talent translates into impact. From your first day, you ll be working with some of the world s most highly-skilled digital professionals, all contributing their knowledge to make change on a national scale.

Join us for rewarding work that makes a difference across the UK. You'll solve some of the nation s highest-priority digital challenges, helping millions of people access services they need.

The Government Data Team is helping transform how government manages, shares and uses data. We are building the foundations that enable data to be treated as a strategic asset across the public sector, including common

standards, secure access models, interoperable data infrastructure and the capabilities needed to support AI and data-driven services. Working across departments, local government and wider public sector partners, we are developing the shared approaches that make it easier to find, access and use data safely, ethically and at scale.

Job description

Former DSIT recruitment campaigns are continuing as usual, but candidates should be aware that following theGovernment s announcement on the changes to some civil service departments, roles will be subject to the machinery of government moves and will ultimately be in one of the new departments. We will provide more information if you are selected for a role. This work remains of high importance to the civil service, and we thank you for your continued interest.

This is a rare opportunity to shape how data flows across government. As Head of Data Interoperability, you'll:

- lead the development and adoption of the patterns and technical approaches that enable organisations to share and use data consistently
- drive adoption of APIs, interoperable data exchange standards and federated data-sharing approaches across government
- build consensus and influence senior stakeholders to adopt common approaches to data sharing and interoperability
- work with architects, engineers and policy teams to deliver the foundations needed for modern public services and AI-enabled government
- play a leading role in delivering the UK Public Data Infrastructure vision and enabling trusted data sharing at scale

Person specification

We re interested in people who:

- can turn data standards, API specifications and interoperability frameworks into practical approaches that delivery teams can adopt at scale

have established data integration standards, design patterns or API architectures that enable secure and interoperable data sharing across organisational boundaries

have successfully built consensus and driven the adoption of standards, mandates or common technical approaches across organisations and stakeholder groups

can provide strategic leadership on complex interoperability challenges, identifying and describing problems, navigating trade-offs and providing technical assurance on complex integration and data-sharing designs

can anticipate future developments in data interoperability, APIs and data-sharing technologies, and can advise on how to adopt new approaches to realise better value from data

Benefits

Alongside your salary of £71,920, Government Digital Service contributes £20,835 towards you being a member of the Civil Service Defined Benefit Pension scheme. Find out what benefits a Civil Service Pension provides (opens in a new window).

There are many benefits of working at GDS, including:

flexible hybrid working with flexi-time and the option to work part-time or condensed hours

a Civil Service Pension with an average employer contribution of 28.97%

25 days of annual leave, increasing by a day each year up to a maximum of 30 days

an extra day off for the King s birthday

an in-year bonus scheme to recognise high performance

career progression and coaching, including a training budget for personal development

a focus on wellbeing with access to an employee assistance programme

job satisfaction from making government services easier to use and more inclusive for people across the UK

advances on pay, including for travel season tickets

- death in service benefits
- cycle to work scheme and facilities
- access to an employee discounts scheme
- 10 learning days per year
- volunteering opportunities (5 special leave days per year)
- access to a suite of learning activities through Civil Service learning

Any move to Government Digital Service from another employer will mean you can no longer access childcare vouchers. This includes moves between government departments. You may however be eligible for other government schemes, including Tax Free Childcare. Determine your eligibility at https://www.childcarechoices.gov.uk

Office attendance
The Department operates a discretionary hybrid working policy, which provides for a combination of working hours from your place of work and from your home in the UK. The current expectation for staff is to attend the office or non-home based location for 40-60% of the time over the accounting period.
DSIT does not normally offer full home working (i.e. working at home); but we do offer a variety of flexible working options (including occasionally working from home).

Things you need to know

Artificial intelligence

Artificial intelligence can be a useful tool to support your application, however, all examples and statements provided must be truthful, factually accurate and taken directly from your own experience. Where plagiarism has been identified (presenting the ideas and experiences of others, or generated by artificial intelligence, as your own) applications may be withdrawn and internal candidates may be subject to disciplinary action. Please see our candidate guidance (opens in a new window) for more information on appropriate and inappropriate use.

Selection process details

The standard selection process for roles at GDS consists of:

a simple application screening process - We only ask for a CV and cover letter of up to 750 words. Please upload one document containing both your CV and cover letter. Important tip - please ensure that your cover letter includes how you meet the skills and experience listed in the person specification section above

A 20 Minute Technical Phone Screen

a 45 minute video interview which will feature a presentation. Details of the presentation will be shared with invited candidates prior to the interview.

Please upload your CV and Cover Letter as one document.

While we value the use of AI technology to enhance our daily work, we also value the personal touch and urge applicants to write cover letters without the use of AI to emphasise their own unique experiences.

In the event we receive a high volume of applications, we will conduct the initial sift against the lead criteria which is:

can turn data standards, API specifications and interoperability frameworks into practical approaches that delivery teams can adopt at scale

In the Civil Service, we use Success Profiles to evaluate your skills and ability. This gives us the best possible chance of finding the right person for the job, increases performance and improves diversity and inclusivity. We ll be assessing your technical abilities, skills, experience and behaviours that are relevant to this role.

For this role we ll be assessing you against the following Civil Service Behaviours:

working together

changing and improving

leadership

We ll also be assessing your experience and specialist technical skills against the following skills defined in the Government Digital and Data Capability Framework for the Head of Data Engineering (G6) role:

Data Integration Design

Data Development Process

Data Innovation

Want to know more about who Government Digital and Data are? Click Here

Sift completion: 9/11/2026

Phone screens: Starting from 16/11/2026

Panel interviews: Starting from 23/11/2026

Candidates that do not pass the interview but have demonstrated an acceptable standard may be considered for similar roles at a lower grade.

A reserve list will be held for a period of 12 months, from which further appointments can be made.

The Civil Service is committed to attract, retain and invest in talent wherever it is found. To learn more please see the Civil Service People Plan and the Civil Service D&I Strategy.

Feedback will only be provided if you attend an interview or assessment.

Sponsorship

DSIT cannot offer Visa sponsorship to candidates through this campaign. DSIT holds a Visa sponsorship licence but this can only be used for certain roles and this campaign does not qualify.

Feedback will only be provided if you attend an interview or assessment.

Security

Successful candidates must undergo a basic (or equivalent) criminal record check.

Successful candidates must meet the security requirements before they can be appointed. The level of security needed is security check (opens in a new window).

See our vetting charter (opens in a new window).

People working with government assets must complete baseline personnel security standard (opens in new window) checks.

Nationality requirements

This job is broadly open to the following groups:

- UK nationals
- nationals of the Republic of Ireland
- nationals of Commonwealth countries who have the right to work in the UK
- nationals of the EU, Switzerland, Norway, Iceland or Liechtenstein and family members of those nationalities with settled or pre-settled status under the European Union Settlement Scheme (EUSS) (opens in a new window)
- nationals of the EU, Switzerland, Norway, Iceland or Liechtenstein and family members of those nationalities who have made a valid application for settled or pre-settled status under the European Union Settlement Scheme (EUSS)
- individuals with limited leave to remain or indefinite leave to remain who were eligible to apply for EUSS on or before 31 December 2020
- Turkish nationals, and certain family members of Turkish nationals, who have accrued the right to work in the Civil Service

Further information on nationality requirements (opens in a new window)

Working for the Civil Service

The Civil Service Code (opens in a new window) sets out the standards of behaviour expected of civil servants.

We recruit by merit on the basis of fair and open competition, as outlined in the Civil Service Commission's recruitment principles (opens in a new window).

The Civil Service embraces diversity and promotes equal opportunities. As such, we run a Disability Confident Scheme (DCS) for candidates with disabilities who meet the minimum selection criteria.

The Civil Service also offers a Redeployment Interview Scheme to civil servants who are at risk of redundancy, and who meet the minimum requirements for the advertised vacancy.

Diversity and Inclusion

The Civil Service is committed to attract, retain and invest in talent wherever it is found. To learn more please see the Civil Service People Plan (opens in a new window) and the Civil Service Diversity and Inclusion Strategy (opens in a new window).

Apply and further information

This vacancy is part of the Great Place to Work for Veterans (opens in a new window) initiative.

The Civil Service welcomes applications from people who have recently left prison or have an unspent conviction. Read more about prison leaver recruitment (opens in new window).

Once this job has closed, the job advert will no longer be available. You may want to save a copy for your records.

Contact point for applicants

Job contact :

Name : gdsrecruitment@dsit.gov.uk

Email : gdsrecruitment@dsit.gov.uk

Recruitment team

Email : gdsrecruitment@dsit.gov.uk

Further information

If you feel your application has not been treated in accordance with the Recruitment Principles and you wish to make a complaint, you should contact gds-complaints@dsit.gov.uk in the first instance.

If you are not satisfied with the response you receive you can contact the Civil Service Commission by email: info@csc.gov.uk Or in writing: Civil Service Commission, Room G/8 1 Horse Guards Road, London, SW1A 2HQ.

Civil Service Commission

disability confident EMPLOYER